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Enhancing person-job fit: Who needs a strengths-based leader to fit their job?

Marianne van Woerkom [a,*], Robin Bauwens [a], Sait Gürbüz [b,c], Evelien Brouwers [c]

[a] Department of Human Resource Studies, Tilburg University, Netherlands
[b] International Business School, Hanze University of Applied Sciences, Netherlands
[c] TRANZO Scientific Center for Care and Wellbeing, Tilburg University, Netherlands

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ABSTRACT

Even though person-job fit (PJ fit) is a crucial predictor of employees' overall engagement and performance in their jobs, few studies have identified the mechanisms that enhance PJ fit during the employment relationship. Further, the models that do predict how PJ fit evolves over time are predominantly based on the idea that fit improves through individual adjustment processes by workers. This paper provides a new lens on PJ fit that is based on strengths theory, proposing that strengths-based leaders play a critical role in enhancing both dimensions of PJ fit, i.e. needs-supplies (NS) and demands-abilities (DA) fit, by encouraging employees to use their unique strengths. Furthermore, based on theorizing on substitutes for leadership, proactive career management, and situational strength theory we test the idea that high levels of proactive personality and job autonomy may partly compensate for a lack of strengths-based leadership. We collected three waves of data with two-month time lags from a representative sample of 308 Dutch workers, resulting in 906 datapoints. Results of multi-level path modeling indicate that strengths-based leadership is indeed positively related to both DA fit and NS fit and mediated by strengths use at the within-person level. Further, our results indicate that the combination of high job autonomy and high proactive personality partly compensates for the absence of strengths-based leadership on the within-person level. We conclude that strengths-based leadership is particularly important to facilitate strengths use and PJ fit of employees who have a low propensity to be proactive and/or do not have a high degree of autonomy in their job. We discuss the implications of these findings for research and practice.

Since person-job fit (PJ fit) is a crucial predictor of positive employee attitudes and behaviors such as job satisfaction, organizational commitment, work engagement and turn-over (Kim et al., 2020; Kristof-Brown et al., 2005; Rayton et al., 2019) it is imperative for researchers to uncover the drivers of PJ fit (Kristof-Brown et al., 2005; Vleugels et al., 2023). As both the individual and the job are dynamic entities (Kim et al., 2020), with the motivations and abilities of workers, as well as the job requirements and necessary skills, evolving over time (Kooij et al., 2017), examining fluctuations in person-job fit as an outcome of the dynamic adjustment process between employees and their work environment requires a temporal approach (Vleugels et al., 2023).

Whereas most temporal studies of PJ fit have focused on how fit changes in the pre-hire or early phases of employment (Ehrhart, 2006; Vleugels et al., 2023) some studies have also examined PJ fit after the initial socialization phase. However, the frameworks and

* Corresponding author.
E-mail address: m.vanwoerkom@uvt.nl (M. van Woerkom).

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models that inform these studies, such as the interactional model of Person-Organization fit (Chatman, 1989) and the theory of work adjustment (Dawis & Lofquist, 1984) have inspired a central role for workers in restoring and upholding fit with their work environment through ongoing adjustment processes (Vleugels et al., 2023). This includes engaging in developmental activities (e.g., Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Sylva et al., 2019), job crafting or negotiating job change (Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Kooij et al., 2017) or affective self-regulation (e.g., Gabriel et al., 2014). Nevertheless, an exclusive focus on workers adjustment processes is incomplete from a theoretical point of view, and practically, does not align with today's labor market realities where companies struggle to retain employees (Singh, 2019; van der Spek & Sylva, 2019).

In addition to approaches that solely highlight the role of employees in maintaining their own person-job fit after the socialization phase, this paper investigates the role that leaders can play in facilitating PJ fit by supporting workers to leverage their strengths at work. We build on strengths theory (Peterson & Seligman, 2004) to propose that strengths-based leaders, who help their employees to identify, utilize, and develop their strengths at work (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023) can play an important role in facilitating both dimensions of PJ fit perceptions, i.e. needs-supplies (NS) and demands-abilities (DA) fit (Cable & DeRue, 2002). Strengths refer to pre-existing capacities "for a particular way of behaving, thinking, or feeling that is authentic and energizing to the user, and enables optimal functioning, development, and performance" (Linley, 2008, p. 9). Since workers' strengths enable them to perform at their personal best, and direct supervisors can allocate tasks according to employees' strengths (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023), strengths-based leadership is likely to promote employee strengths use and thereby enhance the fit between the demands of the job and a person's abilities. Also, since strengths convey a sense of ownership and authenticity, and people yearn to act in accordance with their strengths (Peterson & Seligman, 2004), strengths-based leadership can improve the alignment between workers' needs and job provisions, by fostering an environment where employees feel acknowledged for their positive attributes.

Nevertheless, in contemporary dynamic work environments, employees themselves still play a crucial role in proactively managing their abilities, needs, and working conditions to establish a good fit with their work environment (Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Grant & Parker, 2009; Sylva et al., 2019). Workers with high levels of proactive personality identify opportunities to improve work processes and to use and develop their skills (Marstand et al., 2017; Seibert et al., 2001). This suggests that they may rely less on their leaders to utilize their strengths and to enhance their PJ fit. Therefore, drawing on the literature on proactive career behavior (Sylva et al., 2019) and substitutes for leadership (Kerr & Jermier, 1978; Podsakoff et al., 1996), we propose that a high level of proactive personality may partly compensate for lower levels of strengths-based leadership. However, we also hypothesize that this substitution effect will depend on the strength of the job environment (Mischel, 1977), of which job autonomy is seen as an important indicator (Barrick & Mount, 1993; Fuller Jr et al., 2010). In 'weak' situations, which feature high levels of job autonomy and ambiguous signals about expected behaviors, proactive personality has more room to shape job performance. In contrast, 'strong' situations, marked by low job autonomy and clear instructions on required behaviors, offer less opportunity for proactive personality to impact job behavior (Barrick & Mount, 1993). Therefore, we hypothesize that proactive personality is more likely to moderate the effect of strengths-based leadership when employees have a high level of job autonomy (Cortina et al., 2022; Fuller Jr et al., 2010).

In this paper, we examine to what extent strengths-based leadership influences PJ fit mediated by employee strengths use at the within-person level and to what extent this mechanism is influenced by cross-level interactions with proactive personality and job autonomy at the between-person level. It is important to note that where we speak of PJ fit, we refer to subjective perceptions of fit rather than objective or calculated forms of fit (Edwards et al., 2006). We expect that at moments when workers perceive their leader to focus more on their strengths, they are more likely to use their strengths and therefore to perceive a good DA- and NS fit. Further, we expect that workers with high levels of proactive personality and job autonomy are less reliant on a strengths-based leader for facilitating their strengths use and PJ fit. Therefore, we test the cross-level three-way interaction between strengths-based leadership, job autonomy and proactive personality on strengths use, and in turn PJ fit.

Our study contributes to the literature on PJ fit in two important ways. First, we challenge the assumption underlying PJ fit theory that *only* workers have a role to play in ensuring their fit with the work environment after the initial socialization period (Vleugels et al., 2023). The dominance of this approach is understandable given that employees may have a greater capacity to adjust their needs and abilities compared to employers altering the demands and provisions of jobs. For instance, changing job demands or supplies may involve changing organizational practices or policies, making different task divisions, or reallocating resources, which is typically time-consuming and meets with resistance (Kim et al., 2020). However, this approach denies the important role that leaders have in adapting job roles to better fit the different capabilities of employees (Bui et al., 2017; Choi et al., 2017) and in satisfying worker's needs (Kovjanic et al., 2013; Sedlářík et al., 2024). Building on recent literature and theorizing on strengths and strengths-based leadership (van Woerkom et al., 2022; Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023) we provide a new lens on fostering PJ fit, emphasizing the significance of leaders in aligning the job with the needs and abilities of the worker, rather than solely focusing on the adaptability of employees. However, by investigating how strengths-based leadership interacts with proactive personality and job autonomy, we also recognize that the influence of leadership remains contingent on individual and job-related factors.

Second, whereas most studies that have examined predictors of PJ fit during the employment relationship are based on cross-sectional data (e.g., Boon et al., 2011) this is problematic as both the individual and the job are dynamic entities (Kim et al., 2020) and in the current labor market, PJ fit is more often fluctuating than stable (Sylva et al., 2019). We take a temporal approach by investigating how strengths use and PJ fit change over time due to changes in strengths-based leadership. This is in line with previous studies that show that strengths use (Moore et al., 2024; van Woerkom, Oerlemans and Bakker, 2016) and leadership (Breevaart et al., 2014; Rudolph, Breevaart and Zacher, 2022) are dynamic phenomena. Nevertheless, whereas leadership behaviors and employee behaviors fluctuate over time, other aspects of the job and the worker are known to be fairly stable. The leadership literature has called for more research on how follower characteristics alter the influence of leadership over time (Kelemen et al., 2020), while the fit

literature would benefit from a better understanding of the boundary conditions of strategies to promote fit, shedding light on when, why, and how person-job fit evolves following the initial socialization period (Vleugels et al., 2023). Therefore, we examine the mechanisms causing within-person changes in PJ fit, and their cross-level interactions with the more stable constructs of proactive personality and job autonomy (see Fig. 1).

1. Theory and hypotheses

1.1. The relationship between strengths-based leadership and PJ fit

PJ fit, referring to the alignment between the needs of an employee and what is supplied by a job (NS fit) and the abilities of a person, and the demands of the job (DA fit) (Cable & DeRue, 2002), is a crucial predictor of how employees feel about their job, but also of their job performance (Kristof-Brown et al., 2005). According to theories on person-environment fit, of which PJ fit is an element, stress does not arise from the person or environment separately, but from the incompatibility between an individual and his or her environment. In particular, stress arises when the environment does not provide adequate supplies to meet the person's needs, or when the abilities of the person fall short of the demands of the job (Edwards et al., 1998). This stress may lead to psychological, physiological, and behavioral strains, such as dissatisfaction, boredom, anxiety, and depression (Edwards & van Harrison, 1993; Warr & Inceoglu, 2012). Most research on PJ fit has drawn from Schneider's (1987) attraction-selection-attrition (ASA) framework, which posits that employees who 'fit' will stay in their jobs, while those who do not will leave (Sylva et al., 2019). However, given the dynamic nature of today's work environment, marked by continuous developments and the increasing importance of employees who drive change and manage their own working conditions, workers' PJ fit experiences are known to vary over time (Sylva et al., 2019; Vleugels et al., 2018).

We propose that changes in leadership behavior are associated with changes in PJ fit over time. Traditionally, leaders have seen workers' deficits as their greatest area of opportunity (Bouskila-Yam & Kluger, 2011; Roberts et al., 2005) and have therefore tried to enhance PJ fit by adapting workers skills and abilities to the requirements of the job, for example with training, feedback, or performance appraisal. In contrast, strengths theory (Biswas-Diener et al., 2011; Peterson & Seligman, 2004), has provided a new perspective on how to foster PJ fit by identifying workers' strengths and facilitating them in using these strengths at work.

Strengths-based leaders aim to facilitate the PJ fit of their workers by helping them to identify their unique strengths and to build their job around these strengths, instead of trying to fix their weaknesses to better fit the job (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023). Strengths-based leaders are in an excellent position to help their followers in identifying their strengths by observing them in their task performance and recognizing their instinctive preferences for using specific strengths (Linley et al., 2007). Subsequently, they can provide their followers with feedback about the times that they were at their personal best (Lee et al., 2016) and allocate tasks and roles that fit their strengths (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023).

More specifically, strengths-based leaders can enhance employees' perception of DA fit by appreciating the strengths of their workers, thereby creating a supportive working environment (Babakus et al., 2010). This promotes employee motivation and

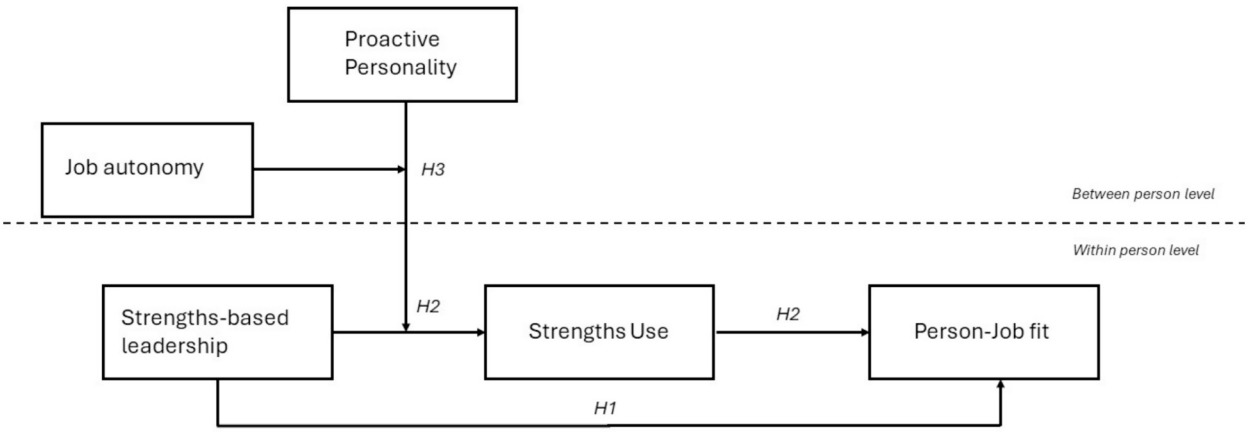

Fig. 1. Conceptual model.

optimism, and therefore the belief that they have fitting abilities to meet the requirements of their jobs and tasks (Tims et al., 2011). Also, by helping employees to identify and develop their unique strengths and encouraging them to build their job around these strengths, strengths-based leaders might foster employees' perceptions of NS fit by satisfying their needs for competence, autonomy, and relatedness (Choi et al., 2017).

The ways in which (strengths-based) leaders engage with followers may however fluctuate over time (Breevaart et al., 2014; Rudolph, Breevaart and Zacher, 2022). Over time, leaders may face diverse projects, time constraints, bureaucratic hurdles, and work-life balance challenges (Morf & Bakker, 2024), all of which can impact their implementation of strengths-based leadership. In today's modern work environments, while in-depth interactions between supervisors and employees may not occur daily (Golden & Fromen, 2011), they are often concentrated in regular check-ins to maintain communication and provide guidance. Research suggests that more and more organizations are replacing their annual performance appraisals by quarterly or bimonthly meetings (Cappelli & Tavis, 2016; Pulakos et al., 2015; Sarkar, 2016; Tseng & Levy, 2019). Since these check-ins are meant to enhance the two-way communication between supervisor and subordinate (Sarkar, 2016), they present significant moments for leaders to address the strengths of their employees, which may result in changes in the perceptions of strengths-based leadership and in turn DA- and NS fit. Therefore, for our research design we opted for a bimonthly time lag, which is also in line with studies that show that leadership (Rudolph, Breevaart and Zacher, 2022) and PJ fit (Kim et al., 2020) fluctuate on a multiple-monthly basis.

Based on the reasoning presented above, we hypothesize the following:

Hypothesis 1. There is a direct relationship between employee perceived strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit (within-person level).

1.2. The mediating role of strengths use

Even though we expect that strengths-based leadership will be directly related to DA and NS fit, we also expect that strengths use will play an important mediating role in these relationships. Since strengths pertain to individual traits that enable someone to excel or perform at their personal best (Peterson & Seligman, 2004), and strengths-based leaders align workers' job tasks with their strengths, strengths-based leadership is likely to enhance DA fit via its effect on strengths use. When employees utilize their strengths, they leverage their innate abilities, and research indicates a direct relationship between ability and performance (Coward & Sackett, 1990). This suggests that individuals who can utilize their strengths in their work are more likely to perceive a strong alignment between their abilities and the job demands (Meyers et al., 2023).

However, using one's signature strengths also goes together with a sense of ownership and authenticity, leading to feelings of congruency with the environment in which one operates (Kuntz & Abbott, 2017; van den Bosch et al., 2019), which is likely to result in an improved NS fit. People yearn to act in accordance with their strengths (Peterson & Seligman, 2004) and strengths use is concordant with one's needs and intrinsic values (Linley et al., 2010), leading to a fulfilling experience (Mahomed & Rothmann, 2020). Also, when individuals can utilize their strengths at work, they tend to establish deeper connections with others, and perceive their work as more meaningful (Moore et al., 2024), thereby satisfying their needs for relatedness (van den Broeck et al., 2010) and meaning (Vogel et al., 2020).

Whereas the link between strengths use and PJ fit has never been investigated in the work context, van Niekerk et al. (2016) found that student's strengths use increased the perceived fit with their study material. Furthermore, according to Berg et al. (2008), employees can create a better PJ fit by crafting their job in line with their "motives, strengths and passions" (p. 13), thereby creating an environment that better matches their personal characteristics (van Vianen, 2017), as was evidenced by Kooij et al. (2017).

Just like leadership and PJ fit, strengths use is not a stable trait but a dynamic phenomenon that is sensitive to environmental influences such as support for strengths use (Moore et al., 2024; van Woerkom, Mostert, et al., 2016). Therefore, we expect that fluctuations in strengths-based leadership will be associated with fluctuations in PJ fit through fluctuations in strengths use. Based on the previous reasoning we hypothesize the following:

Hypothesis 2. The relationship between employee perceived strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit is partially mediated by strengths use (within-person level).

1.3. Proactive personality and job autonomy as substitutes for strengths-based leadership

Research and theorizing on substitutes for leadership (Kerr & Jermier, 1978) suggests that a variety of subordinate characteristics may influence the relationship between leaders' behaviors and employee outcomes, by acting in place of these leadership behaviors (Velez & Neves, 2017). According to this literature, the relationship between leadership and follower behavior gets weaker if followers believe that they have what it takes to successfully accomplish a task (Den Hartog & Belschak, 2012).

Strengths-based leaders motivate their workers to use their strengths by communicating that there is not one 'golden standard' of going about their tasks, but that they should use their unique qualities and craft their job in line with their strengths (van Woerkom, Oerlemans, & Bakker, 2016). It is likely that workers with a high level of proactive personality, referring to an individual's tendency to take intentional action to influence their environment (Bateman & Crant, 1993), are more self-sufficient in actively redesigning their job and withstanding the tendency to conform to their coworkers in their task execution (Hewlin, 2009). This is in line with the literature on proactive career behavior (e.g., Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Grant & Parker, 2009; Sylva et al., 2019), which suggests that, particularly in today's dynamic and uncertain work environments, employees play a crucial role in proactively managing their abilities, needs, and working conditions to establish a good fit with their work environment (Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Griffin &

Hesketh, 2003; Kooij, 2015). Highly proactive workers, who actively identify opportunities to improve work processes and develop their skills (Marstand et al., 2017; Seibert et al., 2001), are therefore less likely to rely on their leaders to leverage their strengths and enhance their person-job fit. By taking the initiative to shape their work environment in line with their abilities and preferences (Bateman & Crant, 1993; Loi et al., 2016), they create opportunities for using their strengths, for example, by volunteering for new projects, redistributing tasks with coworkers, or experimenting with new work methods (Berg et al., 2013). Therefore, drawing on the literature on substitutes for leadership (Kerr & Jermier, 1978; Podsakoff et al., 1996) and proactive career behavior (Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Sylva et al., 2019), we propose that a high level of proactive personality may partly compensate for lower levels of strengths-based leadership.

However, the influence of personality traits on behavior is stronger in unstructured or 'weak' situations that do not provide clear cues regarding desired behaviors compared to structured or 'strong' situations that provide powerful cues to perform specified behaviors (Mischel, 1977). In organizational contexts, job autonomy, referring to the discretion that workers must make their own decisions and select their preferred methods when performing their tasks (Hackman & Oldham, 1975), is commonly used as a measure of situational strength (Barrick & Mount, 1993; Fuller Jr et al., 2010). Therefore, it seems likely that job autonomy determines the scope for proactive personality to influence work behavior (Fuller Jr et al., 2010; Parker et al., 2006). Indeed, previous studies have found that a low level of job autonomy weakens the effect of proactive personality on work behavior (Fuller Jr et al., 2010; Liguori et al., 2013).

This suggests that workers with a strong propensity to be proactive may operate less proactively in using their strengths when they perceive low levels of job autonomy, for example due to detailed work rules or explicit consequences for deviating from expected task behavior (Fuller Jr et al., 2010). In such situations, these workers would still benefit from a strengths-based leader who might point them to opportunities for using their strengths despite their restricted job autonomy. In contrast, highly proactive workers who experience high levels of job autonomy do not experience clearly defined expectations regarding how and when they perform their tasks and do not expect negative consequences for deviating from traditional task behavior. This enables them to try new ways of accomplishing their work assignments by using their strengths even without the support of a strengths-based leader.

Based on the reasoning above we expect that workers with a significant predisposition to be proactive and who perceive a high level of job autonomy, are likely to experiment with new ways of using their strengths in their task execution and are therefore less in need of a strengths-based leader. Even though proactive personality and job autonomy are stable factors, they might still influence the within-person effect that strengths-based leadership has on strengths use in such a way that workers who score high on both trait level variables are less susceptible to fluctuations in strengths-based leadership. Based on the reasoning above and on our first hypothesis, we hypothesize the following:

Hypothesis 3. The mediated relationship between employee perceived strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit via strengths use is attenuated by a combination of high proactive personality and high job autonomy (within-person level).

2. Methods

2.1. Sample and procedure

Data were collected in September 2021 using the Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences (LISS) panel controlled by CentERdata (Tilburg University). The panel members consist of Dutch individuals who were selected from the population registry using a random sampling procedure. Every year, the LISS Panel members fill out a follow-up survey covering a variety of themes including education, political viewpoints, and work preferences. Further information on the LISS Panel and CentERdata is accessible at: www.lissdata.nl. Prior to data collection, the ethics review board of a university in the Netherlands (registration number RP606) granted approval for the study design, protocol, and data management plan. All participants provided written informed consent through the LISS panel.

We collected three waves of data with a two-month time lag. Even though leadership studies (Rudolph, Breevaart and Zacher, 2022) usually use longer time lags (e.g., 6 months–1 year, or longer; see Nielsen, Randall, Yarker, & Brenner (2008)) we opted for time lags of two months in line with suggestions to use relatively shorter lags in longitudinal panel studies (Dormann & Griffin, 2015) and with the current trend to replace annual performance appraisals by regular check-ins (i.e., on a quarterly or bimonthly basis) (Boice & Kleiner, 1997; Cappelli & Tavis, 2016; Pulakos et al., 2015). Based on other studies that have used shorter time lags (Niessen et al., 2017; Rudolph, Breevaart and Zacher, 2022; Volmer et al., 2011), we deemed two months to be a proper time frame for temporal fluctuations in employees' perceptions of strengths-based leadership.

The first wave (T1) took place in September 2021 and included an online questionnaire that was sent to 597 randomly selected members of the LISS panel who work at various organizations. The research subjects were selected based on two criteria by CentErdata: The participants had a paid job and worked for a medium-sized or large organization ($\geq$ 50 employees). After two weeks, a reminder was given to participants who had not responded to the survey. Overall, we received 1006 responses from 401 unique individuals: 401 responses on the first wave (T1), 315 on the second wave (T2) of data collection in November 2021, and $N = 290$ participants on the third wave (T3) in January 2022. Since the average attrition rate of 21.15 % was well within the accepted boundaries (10–30 %; Allan, 2018) we concluded that systematic attrition was no concern. To investigate potential non-response bias, we made a comparison between unique individuals who provided responses at all three timepoints ($n = 290$) and those who did not ($n = 111$). This comparison did not show significant disparities in terms of gender ($\chi^2 = (1) = 2.383, p = .123$) or level of education ($\chi^2 = (8) = 11.149, p = .193$). However, a minor yet statistically significant difference was observed in participants' age ($F\,(1, 399) = 11.146, p \leq .001$), with

respondents being marginally older (M = 48.90 years) compared to non-responders at T3 (M = 44.15 years).

After matching individuals to their timepoints and removing single participations, we retained 906 timepoints (L1) from 308 unique individuals (L2). About half were female (46.70 %). The average age was 46.66 (SD = 12.35), and the average organizational tenure was 13.06 (SD = 11.63). In terms of educational level, most participants (84.40 %) had an intermediate vocational degree or above, and a fixed-term contract (89.50 %).

2.2. Measures

Strengths-Based Leadership was measured at T1-T3 with a scale developed by Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023 that was based on the measure perceived organizational support for strengths use (van Woerkom, Mostert, et al., 2016). Example items are 'My leader gives me the opportunity to do what I am good at' and 'My leader ensures that my strengths are aligned with my job tasks'. To capture participants' momentary assessment of these items we asked them to indicate their level of agreement (ranging from 1- totally disagree, to 7 - totally agree) with each statement at that specific timepoint. Cronbach's alphas ranged between 0.93 and 0.94.

Proactive Personality was measured at T1 with six items of a Dutch version (Claes et al., 2005) of a scale developed by Bateman and Crant (1993) including items such as 'If I see something I don't like, I fix it' and 'No matter what the odds, if I believe in something I will make it happen'. Answers were provided on a five-point Likert scale (ranging from 1 -totally disagree, to 5 -totally agree). Cronbach's alpha was 0.84.

Job Autonomy was measured at T1 with a four-item scale developed by Van Veldhoven et al. (2014). Items referred to autonomy regarding work methods and timing and were similar to those proposed by Jackson et al. (1993). A sample item is 'Can you organize your work yourself?'. Answers were provided on a five-point frequency scale (ranging from 1 – never, to 5 - very often). Cronbach's alpha was 0.80.

Strengths use was measured at T1-T3 with a six item scale developed by van Woerkom, Oerlemans, and Bakker (2016). Example items are 'I use my strengths at work' and 'I organize my job to suit my strong points'. To capture participants' momentary assessment of these items we asked them which of the answer options (ranging from 0 - hardly ever, to 6 - almost always) best reflected their current situation. Cronbach's alphas ranged between 0.91 and 0.94.

DA fit was measured at T1-T3 with a three-item scale (Cable & DeRue, 2002). An example item is 'The match is very good between the demands of my job and my personal skills'. Cronbach's alphas ranged between 0.88 and 0.92.

NS fit was measured at T1-T3 with a three-item scale (Cable & DeRue, 2002). An example item is 'There is a good fit between what my job offers me and what I am looking for in a job'. Cronbach's alphas ranged between 0.92 and 0.94. To capture participants' momentary assessment of items pertaining to DA fit and NS fit we asked them to indicate their level of agreement (ranging from 1 - strongly disagree, to 5 - strongly agree) with each statement at that specific timepoint.

We controlled our analyses for gender, age, and education since these variables have been found to correlate with strengths use and/or PJ fit dimensions. For example, previous studies found that females perceive a lower PJ fit (Yousaf et al., 2022), and that age is positively (Dubreuil et al., 2014), and educational level is negatively associated with strengths use (Chu et al., 2022).

2.3. Instrument validation and common method variance (CMV)

We performed a multi-level CFA in R on the long version of the data (i.e. with rows representing timepoints), considering the temporal stability of proactive personality and autonomy, and the temporal variability of strengths-based leadership, strengths use, needs supplies fit and demands abilities fit to test the hypothesized factor structure (see Table S1 in the Online Appendix). The results showed a good fit of the data to a six-factor model with strengths-based leadership, proactive personality, job autonomy, strengths use, DA fit, and NS fit as separate factors ($\chi^2 = 1026.780$, $df = 386$; CFI = 0.935; TLI = 0.927; RMSEA = 0.061; SRMR = 0.051). This model had a better fit than a five-factor model distinguishing strengths-based leadership, proactive personality, job autonomy, strengths use, and person-job fit as separate factors ($\Delta\chi^2 = 10.637$; $\Delta df = 3$; $p < .050$), a four-factor model with strengths-based leadership and strengths use merged in one factor ($\Delta\chi^2 = 311.649$; $\Delta df = 5$; $p < .001$), a four-factor model with strengths-based leadership and person-job fit merged in one factor ($\Delta\chi^2 = 232.930$ $\Delta df = 7$; $p < .001$), a three-factor model with strengths-based leadership, strengths use, and person-job fit merged in one factor ($\Delta\chi^2 = 480.552$; $\Delta df = 10$; $p < .001$), or a one-factor model ($\Delta\chi^2 = 3650.626$; $\Delta df = 19$; $p < .001$).

In addition, we conducted a longitudinal invariance test with CFA on the wide version of the data (i.e. with rows representing unique individuals) to detect model invariance across the three measurement occasions (T1, T2, and T3). We compared models on which progressive model constraints had been imposed (Vandenberg & Lance, 2000). The results are provided in Table 1. First, we examined the consistency of the factor structure by estimating all parameters without constraints across different measurement points,

Table 1
Longitudinal invariance test.

	χ^2	df	χ^2/df	CFI	RMSEA	SRMR	$\Delta\chi^2$	Δdf	p
Model 1. Configurational invariance	5165.393	2259	2.29	0.831	0.071	0.395			
Model 2. Metric invariance	5193.084	2289	2.27	0.831	0.070	0.287	$27.69^{n.s.}$	30	0.987
Model 3. Scalar invariance	4888.157	2316	2.11	0.851	0.066	0.067	$304.927^{n.s.}$	27	1.000

n.s. = not significant; $\Delta\chi 2$ = Sattora-Bentler Scaled Chi-Square Difference.

demonstrating the configurational invariance of our model (Model 1). Subsequently, we constrained the factor loadings to ensure they were identical across measurement points (Model 2). Comparing Model 1 and Model 2 revealed no significant differences, indicating metric invariance ($p = .987$). Lastly, Model 2 was evaluated against a measurement model that constrains the indicator intercepts over time (Model 3). Comparing Model 2 and Model 3 revealed again no significant differences ($p = 1.000$), indicating that scalar invariance can be established. Overall, while the CFI values for all models were slightly below the commonly accepted threshold, the other fit indices, and the non-significant changes in χ^2 suggest that the data meet the criteria for metric and scalar invariance. The improvement in fit from Model 2 to Model 3, as evidenced by better fit indices in Model 3, suggests that constraining the item intercepts to be equal across time did not result in a significantly poorer fit. This implies that the same construct is being measured across time, and that it is appropriate to compare latent means across time points.

Because we used perceptual data, we assessed the presence of common method variance (CMV) by applying the marker variable technique, which involves the use of a theoretically unrelated variable or marker variable (Cooper et al., 2020; Williams et al., 2010). We used the social desirability scale, measured with ten items from Marlow and Crowne (1961) as a marker variable which was not significantly related to the focal variables. The procedure involves testing different nested CFA models including the six focal variables and the marker variable. First, we tested a model in which all variables were freely estimated (CFA model). Second, we tested a model where the marker variable had its correlations set to zero and its loadings and error variances constrained to the results of the CFA model (baseline model). Third, we tested two additional models in which items of the focal variables loaded equally (non-congeneric; method-C model) or varying (congeneric; method-U model) on the latent marker variable. CMV is said to be present if the Method-C or method-U have a significantly better fit than the baseline model. The findings suggest this was not the case (see Table S2 in the Online Appendix): neither the Method-C ($\Delta\chi^2 = 9.476$; $\Delta df = 4$; $p = .578$), nor the method-U model showed an improved fit over the baseline model ($\Delta\chi^2 = 52.520$; $\Delta df = 22$; $p = .092$), suggesting that CMV is not an issue in our data.

2.4. Analytic strategy

Our model represents a cross-level moderated mediation with a 1–1-1 relationship between strengths-based leadership and DA fit and NS fit, partially mediated by strengths use, at the within-person level (level 1) and a three-way interaction of strengths-based leadership with job autonomy and proactive personality at the between-person level (level 2). Since the data had a nested structure with timepoints ($N = 906$) nested within individuals ($N = 308$), multilevel regression was conducted to test the hypotheses. Intraclass correlation coefficients (ICC1s) showed that a significant part of the variance in strengths-based leadership (ICC1 = 35.49 %), strengths use (ICC1 = 40.19 %), DA fit (ICC1 = 35.49 %), and NS fit (ICC1 = 35.50 %) could be explained by differences within persons. While our Level 1 ($n = 308$) and Level 2 ($n = 906$) sample sizes were large enough to test the hypotheses in the research model (L1 $\geq$ 200, L2 $\geq$ 30; Arend & Schäfer, 2019), we also conducted a power analysis. Because a priori power estimation in a multi-wave design is challenging, we performed a post hoc power analysis with G*Power (Erdfelder et al., 1996). With an α of 0.05, our power was 0.77 for detecting the observed effect in the final model.

In the analyses, predictors at the within-level were group-mean centered (Aguinis et al., 2013). To test the moderated mediation, we used the Monte Carlo method (Preacher & Selig, 2012) to produce the conditional indirect effects with 95 % quasi-Bayesian confidence intervals (CIs). Comparable to bootstrapping, this method is more suitable for dealing with clustered data (Hayes, 2018). Analyses were conducted in R with the packages *nlme* (Baldwin et al., 2023; Pinheiro et al., 2007) and *lme4* (Douglas Bates et al., 2015).

All our syntaxes and supplementary tables are available via OSF: https://osf.io/tfv9w/?view_only=2c1980250d0f4a86bf3c8739ed118b0e

3. Results

3.1. Descriptive statistics and correlations

Table 2 displays the correlations, means, and standard deviations. In line with the hypotheses, strengths-based leadership was

Table 2
Descriptive statistics and correlations.

		M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1	Gender (0 = male, 1 = female)	0.48	0.50								
2	Age	46.66	12.35	-0.039							
3	Education	4.30	1.35	0.038	-0.211**						
4	Strengths-based leadership	4.90	1.12	-0.175**	−0.002	-0.047					
5	Proactive personality	3.48	0.56	-0.114**	0.113**	-0.050	0.355**				
6	Job autonomy	3.63	0.88	-0.198**	0.077*	0.160**	0.296**	0.391**			
7	Strengths use	4.41	0.94	-0.083*	0.160**	0.032	0.491**	0.477**	0.358**		
8	DA fit	3.61	0.82	-0.056	0.110**	-0.018	0.507**	0.196**	0.282**	0.478**	
9	NS fit	3.77	0.76	−0.046	0.050	0.087**	0.406**	0.237**	0.328**	0.469**	0.702**

Note. * $p < .050$, ** $p < .010$. Between-level $N = 906$ within-level $N = 308$. Correlations are for the within-level and do not account for the clustered nature of the data.

positively correlated with strengths use ($r = 0.491$, $p < .010$), DA fit ($r = 0.507$, $p < .010$), and NS fit ($r = 0.406$, $p < .010$). Further, strengths use correlated positively with DA fit ($r = 0.478$, $p < .010$), and NS fit ($r = 0.469$, $p < .010$).

3.2. Hypothesis testing

Table 3 presents the models that were estimated to test the hypotheses. We also ran the latter models without control variables and found that all significant results remained the same (see Table S3 in the Online Appendix). Hypothesis 1 proposed direct relationships between strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit. Since the direct effect was not significant for DA fit ($b = 0.01$, $p = .657$), Hypothesis 1a was not supported. For NS fit, the direct effect was significant ($b = 0.16$, $p < .001$), thereby providing support for Hypothesis 1b. Hypothesis 2 stated that the relationship between strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit would be mediated by strengths use. The results show that strengths-based leadership was positively related to strengths use ($b = 0.29$, $p < .001$) and that there was a positive significant relationship between strengths use and both DA fit ($b = 0.11$, $p < .001$) and NS fit ($b = 0.09$, $p < .001$). The indirect effect of strengths-based leadership on DA fit via strengths use was significant (*conditional indirect effect* = 0.032, 95 % *CI* [0.017, 0.050], $p < .001$), thereby confirming Hypothesis 2a. The indirect effect of strengths-based leadership on NS fit via strengths use was significant (*conditional indirect effect* = 0.025, 95 % *CI* [0.012, 0.040], $p < .001$), thereby confirming Hypothesis 2b.

Hypothesis 3 stated that the mediated relationship between strengths-based leadership and (a) DA fit and (b) NS fit via strengths use would be attenuated by a combination of high proactive personality and high job autonomy (within-person level). To test this hypothesis, we tested the different two-way interactions (strengths-based leadership*proactive personality, strengths-based leadership*job autonomy, job autonomy*proactive personality) in addition to the three-way interaction (strengths-based leadership*proactive personality*job autonomy). The two-way interactions were not interpreted, since they were qualified by the significant three-way interaction term ($b = -0.06$, $p < .010$). Simple slope tests indicated that the slope for low job autonomy and low proactive personality was significant ($b = 0.40$, SE = 0.04, $p < .001$), as well as for high levels of job autonomy and proactive personality ($b = 0.13$, SE = 0.04, $p < .001$). To further probe the three-way interaction, we conducted slope difference tests (Dawson & Richter, 2006). The results showed that compared to the slope of the low proactive personality–low job autonomy regression line, the slope of the high proactive personality-high job autonomy line was significantly less steep (*slope difference* = −0.275, $t = -4.583$, $p < .001$), while the slopes of the high proactive personality-low job autonomy, (slope difference = −1.029, $t = -1.682$, $p = .093$), and low proactive personality-high job autonomy lines (slope difference = 0.236, $t = 0.414$, $p = .679$) were not significantly different. This indicates that the impact of strengths-based leadership on strengths use is significantly weaker when individuals possess *both* high proactive personality and high job autonomy. The nature of the three-way interaction is displayed in Fig. 2. The within-cluster index of moderated mediation was −0.038 [−0.072, −0.006] for the moderated mediation with DA fit and − 0.033 [−0.066, −006] for the moderated mediation with NS fit, suggesting the presence of moderated mediation for both dimensions of PJ fit as zero is absent from both intervals. Together these results lend support to Hypothesis 3.

4. Discussion

Even though PJ fit results from an individuals' continuous interaction with the work environment (Su et al., 2015), person-environment fit theory, of which PJ fit is an element, suffers from a significant lack of understanding of the dynamic nature of fit

Table 3
Hierarchical multiple regression analysis predicting strengths use, DA fit and NS fit ($N = 308$ between; $N = 906$ within).

	Strengths use			DA fit			NS fit		
	Estimate	*SE*	*p*	Estimate	*SE*	*p*	Estimate	*SE*	*p*
Gender (0 = male, 1 = female)	0.10	0.07	.145	0.00	0.05	.997	0.02	0.05	.665
Age	0.01***	0.00	<.001	0.00	0.00	.567	0.00	0.00	.059
Educational level	0.05*	0.03	.042	0.05*	0.02	.010	−0.03	0.02	.214
Strengths-based leadership (SBL)	0.29***	0.03	<.001	0.01	0.02	.657	0.16***	0.02	<.001
Strengths use				0.11***	0.02	<.001	0.09***	0.02	<.001
DA fit							0.53***	0.03	<.001
NS fit				0.57***	0.03	<.001			
Proactive personality (PP)	0.53***	0.07	<.001						
Job autonomy (JA)	0.17***	0.04	<.001						
SBL x PP	−0.13**	0.05	.006						
SBL x JA	−0.09**	0.03	.007						
JA x PP	0.12*	0.06	.030						
SBL x JA x PP	−0.06**	0.02	.006						
Random effects									
Marginal R^2	0.397			0.506			0.515		
Conditional R^2	0.641				0.751		0.809		
AIC	1879.918				1537.337		1476.928		
-2log-Likelihood (deviance)	1853.918				1521.336		1460.928		

Note. *$p < .050$, **$p < .010$, ***$p < .001$. Results of analyses without the control variables gender, age, and educational level were not substantially different.

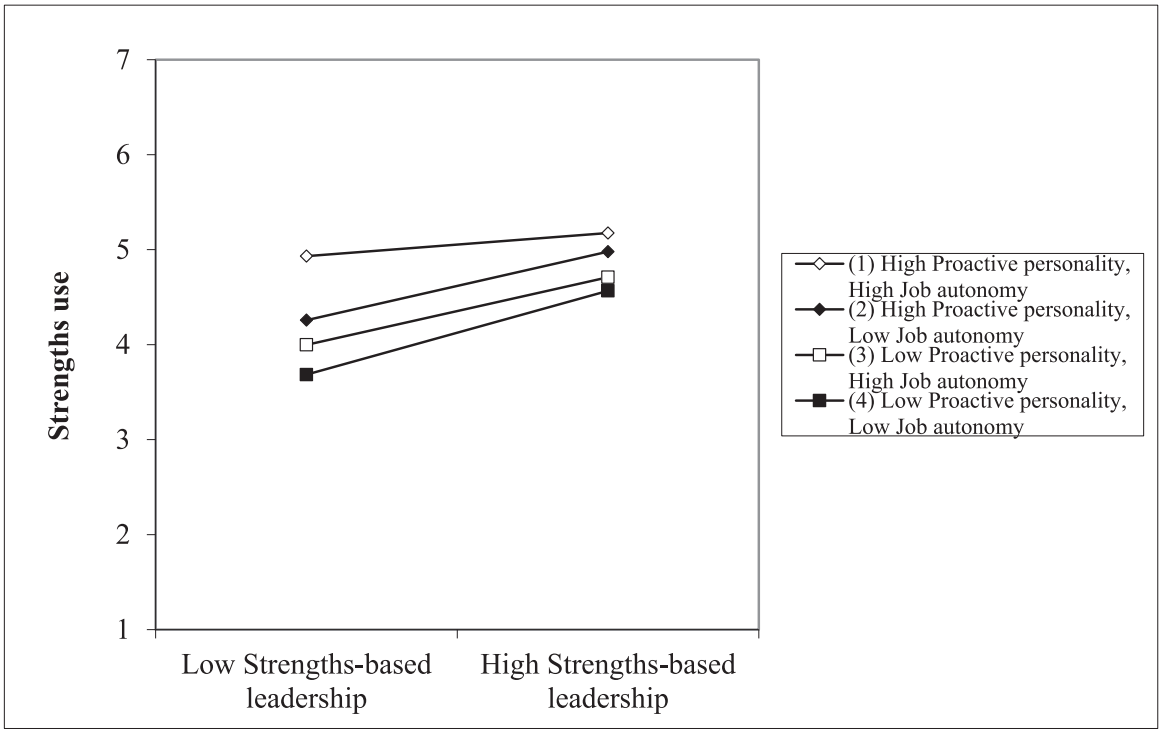

Fig. 2. Plot of the three-way interaction of strengths-based leadership, proactive personality, and job autonomy at the within-person level.

during the employment relationship and its individual level antecedents (Vleugels et al., 2023; Yu, 2009). Further, the models that do predict how PJ fit evolves over time are predominantly based on the idea that fit improves exclusively through individual adjustment processes (Vleugels et al., 2023). In these processes individuals seek congruence with their work environment by changing themselves to meet expectations or lower their expectations to meet reality (Su et al., 2015; Vleugels et al., 2023). However, such a one-sided emphasis on workers adapting to the requirements of their jobs seems outdated in the current era, which is characterized by increasing shortages on the labor market (Ng & Stanton, 2023), a war for talent (Vaiman et al., 2021), and an increasing importance that is attached to the employee experience (Plaskoff, 2017).

Our study indicates that at moments when workers perceive their leader to focus more on their strengths, they are more likely to perceive a good DA- and NS fit. The association between strengths-based leadership and DA fit was fully mediated by strengths use, whereas the relationship between strengths-based leadership and NS fit was only partially mediated by strengths use. These findings shed light on the mechanisms that influence the development of PJ fit over time and provide initial evidence that PJ fit cannot only be created by individual adapting themselves to the work environment, for instance by developing skills that the job requires or changing their expectations in line with what the job has to offer. Instead, we show that PJ fit can be promoted by leaders who try to adapt jobs to the unique strengths and talents of their employees. This provides a new lens on PJ fit that is based on a strengths-based approach to HRM (Gruman & Budworth, 2022). In this perspective, the greatest potential for enhancing optimal functioning and PJ fit lies not in correcting workers' deficient attitudes, skills, or behaviors (Luthans, 2002), but in helping employees to identify their unique strengths and using these strengths at work by adapting the job to the unique qualities of workers (Luthans & Youssef, 2007; Meyers et al., 2023). Even though one previous study already pointed out that a training that stimulates workers to craft their job in line with their strengths may facilitate PJ fit (Kooij et al., 2017), such a training can only provide a one-time intervention to promoting PJ fit. Instead, the current paper shows that strengths-based leaders may impact the development of person-job fit experiences in a dynamic and sustainable way. This is an important finding, since not only workers' motives and abilities (Kooij et al., 2017), but also the job demands and the skills that are needed to do the job are ever changing due to for example computerization, delayering, downsizing, and project-based work (Sylva et al., 2019).

Our finding that the association between strengths-based leadership and DA fit was fully mediated by strengths use can be attributed to the integral role of strengths-based leadership in aligning job demands with employee abilities by tailoring tasks to match employee strengths, thereby bringing employees in a better position to effectively utilize their strengths. Apparently, the behavioral change in strengths use is the primary mechanism responsible for enhancing DA fit, and overpowers other potential mechanisms, such as fostering employee confidence in their ability to meet job requirements (Tims et al., 2011). However, when it comes to the mechanisms that are responsible for bringing about NS fit our findings indicate that in addition to strengths use behaviors there might be other mechanisms that transmit the effects of strengths-based leadership. The rewards a job offers in return for employees' service include recognition and positive working conditions (Cable & DeRue, 2002). These rewards can fulfill workers' needs for relatedness,

competence, and autonomy (Babakus et al., 2010; Choi et al., 2017; Tims et al., 2011). Therefore, it is likely that strengths-based leaders contribute to NS fit by creating a supportive working environment where workers feel appreciated for their unique strengths.

Furthermore, our finding that the combination of high proactive personality and high job autonomy partly compensates for the absence of strengths-based leadership provides further insight in the complex interplay between conditions that predict PJ fit and in the effectiveness of leadership interventions for different types of workers (Su et al., 2015). Strengths-based leadership is of added value to the strengths use and PJ fit of workers that either possess a high proactive personality or high job autonomy or who score low on both aspects. However, workers that possess a unique combination of high proactive personality and high job autonomy benefit less from having a strengths-based leader, as these characteristics compensate for strengths-based leadership, also over time. This is in line with research on substitutes for leadership (Kerr & Jermier, 1978), proactive career management (e.g., Bayl-Smith & Griffin, 2018; Grant & Parker, 2009; Sylva et al., 2019) and situational strength theory (Mischel, 1977), which suggests that the effect of strengths-based leadership gets particularly salient when it provides employees with resources they are lacking, and that workers with a pronounced inclination to be proactive can partly take over the role that strengths-based leaders play in promoting strengths use as long as they have the discretion to make their own decisions and select their preferred work methods in line with their abilities and preferences. Furthermore, in a distinctive contribution to substitutes for leadership theory, this finding suggest that such substitution effects might persist over time, thereby enhancing our comprehension of how certain individual (proactive personality) or contextual factors (job autonomy) can step in to fulfill leadership functions.

Our finding that strengths-based leadership is particularly crucial for employees who are not highly proactive and/or lack a high degree of autonomy in their job may seem to downplay the importance of strengths-based leadership. However, we believe this insight significantly contributes to both theory and practice since intuitively, leaders might focus their support on employees who are already proactive and possess high autonomy. For instance, previous studies found that supervisors are more inclined to provide support to those who are similar to them (Hopkins, 2002; Thompson et al., 2006; Varma et al., 2001). Because leaders are more likely to be proactive (Crossley et al., 2013; Seibert et al., 1999) and usually have a fair amount of job autonomy (Hackman & Wageman, 2007; Northouse, 2021; Preenen et al., 2014), it can be expected that leaders are more inclined to provide support to those who are high in proactive personality and autonomy. This is in line with studies that show that a high amount of control and interesting work were related to higher levels of supervisor support (Sundin et al., 2006) and that personal initiative (van Woerkom, Oerlemans, & Bakker, 2016) and autonomy (Keenan & Mostert, 2013) were positively associated with perceived strengths use support. The findings of our study highlight that the employees who are least likely to receive support from a strengths-based leader might be the ones who benefit most from strengths-based leadership.

4.1. Strengths, limitations and future research

While our study findings shed new light on the mechanisms that influence the development of PJ fit over time and how PJ fit can be promoted by leaders who try to adapt jobs to the unique strengths and talents of their employees, some limitations need to be considered. A first limitation is that our study relies on employee self-report data, which might be susceptible to CMV (Podsakoff et al., 2012). However, in our study self-reported data is appropriate, as variables like strengths use and PJ fit are largely private experiences that can best be assessed by participants themselves (Cooper et al., 2020; George & Pandey, 2017). Moreover, our meticulous approach to data collection, encompassing multiple timepoints and varied response formats in the questionnaire, serves as a robust safeguard against potential CMV pitfalls (Cooper et al., 2020). In addition, several results suggest the presence of CMV in our study was not problematic. Our confirmatory factor analyses clearly demonstrated that the fit of a six-factor model with our six focal variables as separate factors was superior to a one-factor model in which all the items of the focal variables loaded on a single factor. Using the marker technique, we had no indications for CMV in the data, as the baseline model outperformed both the method-C and method-U. In addition, our analysis demonstrated significant (three-way) interaction effects and according to Siemsen et al. (2010, p. 456) "quadratic and interaction effects cannot be artifacts of CMV". Still, future research could further mitigate potential CMV by making use of leader and follower reports of strengths-based leadership to predict a target's strengths use and PJ fit.

Second, even though our measures of strengths-based leadership (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023) and strengths use (van Woerkom, Mostert, et al., 2016) are in line with previous studies, we did not include the definition of strengths in our questionnaire. While our experience indicates that respondents generally understand strengths in line with their theoretical definition, future qualitative studies could offer a deeper exploration of workers' perceptions of their own strengths. This could yield a more nuanced understanding of how individuals interpret their strengths when responding to such questionnaires, which could have significant implications for how leaders can effectively encourage strengths use.

Third, although we collected three waves of data and accounted for the temporal dynamics of the observed relationships, we cannot rule out potential reverse causality. However, the direction of the hypothesized relationships between strengths-based leadership and strengths use (Ding & Yu, 2021; Wang & Ding, 2023), and between strengths use and PJ fit (Berg, 2008; Peterson & Seligman, 2004; Kooij et al., 2017; van Niekerk et al., 2016) align with those established in the literature. Furthermore, supplementary analysis demonstrated worse fit for the reversed model.[1] Nevertheless, future studies could attempt to replicate our results with a longitudinal field experiment, in which strengths-based leadership is manipulated by training managers in the experimental condition and measuring strengths use and PJ fit over time. In addition, our data had slightly lower than desired statistical power (0.77). While close

[1] The hypothesized model had a lower Akaike information criterion (AIC = 18,494) compared to the reverse causality model (AIC = 18,846), suggesting less information loss.

to the conventional threshold (0.80), this restricted our use of more complex analytical techniques to assess causality and moderation, such as Cross-Lagged Panel Models (cf. Eby et al., 2015) and Latent Moderated Structural equations (Ozkok et al., 2022; Su et al., 2019). Future studies may benefit from larger sample sizes to ensure sufficient power for such techniques.

A fourth limitation pertains to the time interval of two months between our measurement waves. We based this time interval on the current trend to replace annual performance appraisals by regular (i.e., on a quarterly or bimonthly basis) check-ins (Cappelli & Tavis, 2016; Pulakos et al., 2015; Sarkar, 2016; Tseng & Levy, 2019) and the idea that these check-ins would provide an important opportunity for strengths-based leadership. However, since most theories of leadership ignore the dimension of time and longitudinal leadership studies usually choose the time lag between leadership inputs and outcomes arbitrarily or based on convenience (Shamir, 2011) we cannot be sure that we picked the right time interval and it is possible that the sometimes modest relationships that we found would have been even stronger when we had chosen another time interval. Therefore, future studies should use both shorter (e.g., daily) and longer (e.g., six months) time lags to establish the time that is needed for strengths-based leadership to affect strengths use and PJ fit. Additionally, future research could concentrate on a single organization, allowing the time interval between measurement waves to be aligned with the timing of check-in meetings between supervisors and subordinates.

A final limitation is that our study focused exclusively on strengths-based leadership, which is concerned with stimulating individual workers to use their unique strengths to better align with their job. Although strengths-based leadership has shown to be distinct from other positive leadership styles such as transformational leadership and humble leadership (Ding et al., 2020), other leadership styles with an emphasis on individual consideration and followers' uniqueness might also benefit strengths use and PJ fit, and therefore deserve further research, preferably in a temporal design. For example, since stimulating (job) autonomy is central to empowering leadership (Cheong et al., 2019), future research could examine the extent to which this leadership style may be substituted by a combination of high levels of proactive personality and job autonomy. In addition, it is important to acknowledge that our study primarily delved into strengths-based leadership in relation to individual strengths use and job alignment. Nevertheless, recent research emphasizes that strengths use can also take on a collective form in team contexts (van Woerkom et al., 2022), which might be more effective when coordinated (Meyers et al., 2023). Hence, exploring how leaders can foster and coordinate collective strengths use and over time also represents a promising avenue for future research.

4.2. Practical implications

Since PJ fit is an important predictor of positive employee behaviors and outcomes, organizations would be wise to invest in ensuring a good PJ fit of their workers. However, until now, the literature has given very little cues on how to enhance the PJ fit of workers on an ongoing basis. By providing evidence that strengths-based leadership enhances employee strengths use and in turn both DA- and NS fit, this paper offers organizations a concrete suggestion to help their workers create a better match with their job. Since leaders tend to focus on preventing performance problems and remediating employee deficits, strengths-based leadership may not come naturally to them (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023). Therefore, organizations should offer training and coaching that supports leaders in acquiring skills in practices like strengths-based coaching and strengths-spotting (Linley, 2010), and strengths-based performance appraisal (van Woerkom & de Bruijn, 2016; van Woerkom & Kroon, 2020). In such a way, leaders might gradually learn to observe their employees in their task performance, recognize their preferences for using specific strengths (Linley et al., 2007), give them feedback about the moments they were at their personal best (Lee et al., 2016), help them understand that there is not one 'golden standard' of going about their tasks, and allocate tasks that suit their strengths (Wang, van Woerkom, Breevaart, Bakker and Xu, 2023). Furthermore, HR managers may support leaders by developing concrete tools that help them to apply a strengths-based focus in activities like recruitment of new staff, and strength-based performance reviews. Since strengths-based leadership is particularly important for workers who lack the combination of a high level of proactive personality and a high level of job autonomy, HR managers might help their managers to look out for these workers and regulate the intensity of their strengths-based leadership behaviors in line with these worker characteristics.

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CRediT authorship contribution statement

Marianne van Woerkom: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Robin Bauwens:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Formal analysis. **Sait Gürbüz:** Investigation, Data curation. **Evelien Brouwers:** Writing – original draft, Funding acquisition.

Declaration of competing interest

I hereby declare that there are no interests or activities for myself or my coauthors that might be seen as influencing the research reported in our paper.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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